



ON THE WRITE LINE

Sunil Gavaskar



FOR MORE
STORIES

WORTH CHECKING WHETHER COMMITMENTS ON BOTH SIDES WERE HONoured DURING MESSI'S KOLKATA VISIT

If he was meant to be at the stadium for an hour, then by leaving well before that time and disappointing fans who had paid good money, the **real culprit** was Messi and his entourage.

In the recently released Hindi film *Dhurandhar*, there's a scene where the Chief of the Indian Intelligence Bureau says, "Indians are India's worst enemies, then Pakistan." Of course, it's a filmy dialogue and has to be seen in the context of the story unfolding on the screen. As someone who has been involved with Indian cricket for more than six decades, starting at the school level, I have seen how, for personal ambitions or grievances, and sometimes even misconceptions and perceived slights, Indian cricket has been dragged by Indians through the mud and its reputation spoiled.

A few days before writing this piece, speculation surfaced that the current broadcast rights holders for ICC cricket were going to walk away from their contractual obligations and leave the ICC in the lurch for the remaining two years of the agreement. There was a flurry of reports until a joint statement from both the ICC and the broadcast rights holder clarified that everything was fine and there was no basis for the claims.

The broadcast rights holder is an Indian company and one of the largest conglomerates in the world, and the current ICC Chair and CEO are also Indians. The first

version of this speculative story appeared in an Indian publication.

The joint statement clearly showed that the speculation was unfounded, but it wasn't altogether surprising that it was an Indian trying to create trouble for fellow Indians. We have had 18 years of the IPL, each a bigger blockbuster than the last, yet every year, within a week or a fortnight of the start of one of the top five sporting properties in the world, we read that viewership has fallen or advertising is not the same as in earlier years. Negative narratives that resurface every few days during the tournament. Why? What pleasure do these Indians get in trying to belittle an Indian sporting property that is the envy of the rest of the world?

Do you ever read such stories in British papers about the English Premier League or Wimbledon or the British Open golf, or even Formula One? Or in American papers about the AFL and the Super Bowl, or in Australian papers about something being wrong with the Boxing Day Test at Melbourne or the New Year's Test in Sydney or the Australian Open tennis event? At least I haven't read, heard or seen speculative or negative stories about the marquee tournaments in these countries. If anything, they go out of their way to project